

EASIA 237 Taketori Unit 1.mp4

Hi everybody, we are beginning a new module today on the tale of the bamboo cutter in Japanese popular culture. And today we'll be starting off that new module with our first unit, covering the earliest version of the story and the one that we'll be focusing on, some adaptations and interpretations of throughout later Japanese history. So the title of today's lecture is Taketori Monogatari: the story and early history. We are beginning a new module; today's lecture will begin with a quick overview of everything we'll be doing for the next three units and then introduce the main story that we'll be focusing on today. tale of the bamboo cutter, which we've looked at in translation. And I'll talk a little bit about the translation, then go over some outlines of the story and some key themes and details to think about purely within the text of the story itself.

Then, after that, I'll attempt to respond to a few obvious questions that might come up whenever we're reading a very old story: Where does the story come from? When was it? Why was it? And what does it mean? It has often been the case, when we're talking about very early pre-modern history, my responses to these questions are often going to be introducing a lot more uncertainties and kind of details. that there's no real conclusive answer to. In this case, we can narrow down quite a bit, but as usual, I want to sort of draw our attention to not just the uncertainties, but I guess the sort of range of possibilities of interpretation that exist in some of these cases. So, there's very very easy, conclusive answers to big questions like this.

But in this case, based on some supporting evidence and kind of circumstantial details, we can make a few, I think, fairly compelling theories about the story and when it originates and this kind of thing. So then, once we sort of go through those key points, I'll wrap things up. with a quick summary that's going to be looking ahead to some of the future parts of this. And then, as usual, I'll give you a quick introduction to the quiz and assignment for this unit. So, as usual, this lecture may end up being somewhat long. The outline that you see here is intended to help you pace yourself and maybe decide when to stop, when to take a break, when you might want to pause to look at some of the other materials, and so on.

I guess one thing I'll say is that I recommend, since what we're looking at for this unit is a primary source reading, that you go ahead and, you know, pause the video now and read that story so you can make your sort of get your own first impressions of it before coming back to look at the rest. Otherwise, if you really want to keep watching right now, you know, the module overview will also not spoil anything. I guess is one way of putting it. Another way of thinking about it is I think looking at the module overview might help you prepare a little bit for how to read the short story before coming back to think about some of those surrounding contextual details that will make a lot more sense once you've already read the story itself.

So, with that in mind, I'll move on to a quick discussion of what we'll be doing throughout this. module So we will be beginning this week introducing the story itself and talking, as I mentioned, in sometimes sort of uncertain terms, sometimes more definitive terms about the early history of

this story, including some kind of precursor narratives that may have preceded the version of the story that we know today, as well as a quick summary of what we can conclude about the context in which this version of the story was developed. Our reading is based on, of course, a translation of the story. I'll say a little bit more about that translation as part of my introduction to the story itself. But like I said, our main concerns.

This week, we are going to be thinking about the early history, the earliest context in which the story was kind of developed and circulated. In unit two, we will still be discussing, to a certain degree, kind of pre-modern culture, moving into the 19th and early 20th centuries, moving into the modern era. This case, this unit of the module, is going to span a pretty broad cross section of Japanese history. Rather than introduce that history in a kind of chronological fashion, we're going to be looking at this story from sort of three different perspectives, three sort of interrelated perspectives. On the one hand, as a work of literature. something that's appreciated for the way that it's written, the way it kind of tells the story, and which exists in a sort of textual form which adds its own set of wrinkles to the situation.

Be considering it as folklore that is, as a source of knowledge or information about the world, or a sort of way of making theories about the world, sort of sharing information about cultural practices, geography, history, things like this. And then, sort of related to this, is what we might call a fairy tale: a story that we might imagine exists primarily to entertain or instruct children, to sort of present a vision of a traditional culture or something like this, moving more towards the modern and interpretations of it. In this case, the reading is going to give us a small piece of this history, thinking primarily about this story as a work of literature and treating it in the context of other similar narratives that were written around the same time as part of the sort of elite court culture for the most part of this period of early Japanese history.

The lecture is going to kind of expand on this to think about its reception in a few different contexts. So we'll be building off of some of what is introduced in the reading, moving a little bit further in history, thinking. about the sort of perhaps what we could call like a rediscovery or reappreciation of the story in the 19th and 20th centuries as an important piece of literary history. And then some maybe alternative branching paths that the story has taken in different periods of history, including some pretty radically different versions of the story, if you can even call them that— some sort of narratives that share a lot of the same details and themes, but are kind of using those for slightly different purposes.

So I'll obviously have more to say about this in Unit 2, but something to look forward to. And then also a few examples of what We might think of as kind of conventional retellings of the story, those that preserve most of the same details and are kind of meant to be presenting to new audiences a version of the story but might sort of adjust some things depending on the context and audience for that. So this is sort of looking ahead into what will be a kind of mini case study within Unit 3, which is really all focused on a somewhat recent, about just over 10 years old at the time of this recording, film adaptation of the story. Perhaps you've heard of it before. It got a fairly wide release when it was.

This is called *The Tale of the Princess Kaguya*, directed by a very famous director of animated films, Isao Takahata, we'll sort of be discussing this alongside a few other more recent adaptations in manga, and then this 2013 animated film. So the reading is going to accompany the film, which you'll also have access to. And then both of those things will play into our lecture for this unit that's going to cover what we can call multimedia adaptations, taking what would have at one point been an orally transmitted tale that became a textually transmitted tale, and turning it into an animated film or a comic book or some other, you know, kind of visual artistic adaptation. So this is going to cover the three units of our module, bringing us from the earliest, earliest known sort of examples of the story all the way until relatively recent history.

Throughout the module, as with the others, we're going to be returning to a few key questions and themes. Some of these will apply more to some units than others. But I think these are good things to keep in mind throughout the next three units of this. One of these is really concerned with this issue of adaptation, right? What are the different kinds of branching paths a story can take as it is told again and again and again? This is kind of the overarching theme of this module. It certainly applies to other modules in the class. But because we're talking about a narrative in this case, we get to be very particular about the way we ask these questions of retelling and adaptation—

kind of story, right? And then how this relates back to adaptation is thinking about the ways that these kind of responses—right, what an audience is getting out of it— might sort of shift the way that that story is adapted, either for that audience or if, you know, a member of the audience sees one particular version of it, is sort of struck by a detail that perhaps other people don't notice. And then, when they go on to create their own version of it they're going to really like elaborate on that detail or focus on it, kind of frame it in a way that brings out that new layer of meaning to the story. We'll also be about, you know, scholarship, I suppose, sort of scholarly study of narratives like this as a kind of audience reception, right?

So when we sort of put on our literary studies hats and think about a text as a work of literature or even as a work of fiction, which I'll say more about during unit two, this sort of leads us to ask certain questions about what the story means. It kind of doesn't necessarily predetermine, but it sort of puts in our minds a few different kinds of questions about what's important to pay attention to. If we're really interested in literary craft, if we're really interested in the nature of storytelling and fiction and these kinds of, you know, fabricated or invented narratives, we're going to be about different elements of the story. Whereas if we're treating it as folklore, if we're treating it as part of a kind of oral culture, we might be asking different questions about it; we might be thinking about it in a slightly different way.

So just like an audience of, you know, a piece of entertainment can respond in different ways to a different text, different kinds of scholars or sort of different scholarly disciplines can create what we can analyze or interpret the significance of a certain work. And these are things that also sort of have the ability to shape our impressions of that text or, you know, other cultural products. So then we can also think about media itself, right? We might think about the dynamics of spoken word storytelling within an oral culture and how this might sort of lead certain kinds of interpretation or certain sort of literary or linguistic features to show up in the way a story is told.

I'll be talking quite a bit in unit two about some of the issues of writing.

as a way to transmit a story or a narrative both in terms of like language use and literary technique but especially in the sense that a piece of writing is an object. Right? This is a material artifact. It has physical form. It's created with a brush or a pen or some other, you know, writing device on some kind of surface. These are things that might seem somewhat incidental to the details of a narrative but if what we want to study is the history of how the story has been preserved and transmitted and shared with other people over time, we do need to pay attention to those material features. Right? To the existence of a text as a physical object. So I'll be briefly referring to some of those ideas and how this influences the study of unit two.

And then when we move on to unit three, we can think about other media, right? What we've talked about in our introductory module of the class as these kind of media-specific features of adaptation and become very interesting to think about when we're talking about, you know, comic books, animated films, other kinds of, like, visual media that can be used to adapt written or oral stories into new forms. And so these are some big questions to think about throughout this module.

Turning now to the more specific subject of the module. The story itself, the Tale of the Bamboo Cutter, we are reading the translation of. For now, just sort of be giving you a like overview of what I'll be talking about to introduce the story. A lot of this I'll elaborate on in the next few slides or so. So, in short, and we'll sort of talk through the story in outline form in a few minutes. But basically, if you've read the story— and I hope at this point you have— before we move on to discuss some details of it, you know that it tells the story of the life of what we could call an otherworldly princess, right? A woman who arrives from another place under somewhat fantastical and mysterious circumstances.

grows up very quickly and is then pursued by various, you know, nobles and officials who want to try to marry her. She, you know, rejects all of them and then returns to her original, you know, point of origin on the moon. As we come to find out, a really important aspect of the story that, of course, I've already referenced: we're reading one version of the story; it exists in many different versions, and it is especially visible today in kind of, you know, picture book-like storytelling form, which is often going to adapt details of the story fairly closely but may still change some significant elements. So we'll be the significance of some of these changes as we move through the module.

The reason I'm pointing this out now is just to remind you that, you know, perhaps you're familiar with the sort of structure of this narrative from some other source. It's really important that you still take the time to read through the version that we're looking at in this class, just to make sure you don't get confused in case some of those details from one version to the next are different from the one that we're looking at. So, what we're reading, the translation by Keane, is based on what's basically the oldest known complete version. There are, again, some wrinkles to this idea. Looking ahead to our discussion of manuscripts and textual history that complicate this a little bit, but basically this is what we could call, you know, the original or like most sort of foundational version of the story, from which most of the others are adapted.

I'll be talking a bit about the early history of the text, what we do and don't know about it. But the conclusion to this that we'll arrive at, that most people agree on, is that this is a text that exists in roughly the way that we know it today, around 909 CE, so early 10th century of the Common Era. This is a very old piece of writing in Japanese literary history. This text was produced in a period of history known as the Heian Period. For the purposes of this class, there's not a whole lot we need to know about it other than it spans the late 8th to the late 12th century. It gets its name because this is the period of Japanese history where the capital was in a city that at that time is known as Heian, which is today the city of Kyoto.

This is just a period of Japanese history that we designate due to the location of the capital and then the political features of court. In this era of Japanese history, that also happens to be a really period for the development of this kind of narrative literary writing. which we'll discuss in a bit more detail and read a bit more about in Unit 2. We know that the written version of the text must have come into being at some point in the early 10th century. We also know that it was pretty well known in some form by about 100 years later. This doesn't mean it wasn't well known before that, but we have pretty good conclusive evidence that when it comes up, most people would say, like, oh, I know that story in the sort of literary context that we're talking about.

There's an interesting kind of lull in attention to the story that we'll be talking about in Unit 2. Then we also know that in the 19th century, maybe a little earlier and then up until the present, it becomes really popular, I guess, as an object of study for literary and historical scholars and linguists and people hoping to sort of recover a narrative of Japan's pre-modern literary history, during which it sort of comes to be recognized as the earliest example of this narrative storytelling form that we'll briefly consider a few other examples of in Unit 2. Our English translation is, in fact, not the first English language translation. It was translated pretty early on, as people in other countries started to pay more and more attention to Japanese literary traditions.

The version that we're reading though again, although it's not the oldest translation of the text, it is also quite old. Although I find it's still very readable. Sometimes, when you read translations that are from a few decades, in this case, more than half a century ago, the English language use can be a bit convoluted or archaic feeling. I don't find that to be the case for this 1955 translation. What we're looking at is, I think, perhaps a revised version of it. I'm not sure the extent of the changes made to the translation, but basically, we're looking at, if this kind of bibliographic detail matters to you, a sort of republication. of this 1955 translation a few decades later in a sort of literary history of Japan.

Now the reason I want to point this out now, it's otherwise not too important to think about, but it's worth sort of considering and kind of keeping this question in the back of your mind. Some of the things we'll talk about in the next unit. The book that this translation appears in is a book that's focused on modern Japanese fiction, you know, fiction from the 20th century in Japan. So, it's again just a point to keep in your mind as we move through this unit. Why would it be important or interesting or necessary to include a narrative from the 10th century in a book that's largely focused on much more recent literary writing, you know, novels, short stories, things like this. So, something to think about as we move on.

So, setting aside those bigger questions about context and reception of the story, let's focus for now just on the story itself. What is the story about? What happens in it? These are details that I hope you've been able to notice yourself as you read through the story. But just to refresh your memory or help us focus a little bit on the different components of it, let's just talk through what happens in the story from the beginning to end. So, of course, it begins with the arrival and discovery of what we come to find out is really the main character of the story even though it's named after her kind of adoptive father, the bamboo cutter. We know that the protagonist of the story is really this mysteriously appearing girl who's discovered as a three-inch tall infant among the bamboo by an old bamboo cutter.

And she's given the name by a fortune teller, given the name *Nayotaki no Kaguya hime*, Shining Princess of the Supple Bamboo that I'll refer to so I don't have to repeat that whole name every time just as *Kaguya*, a kind of abbreviation of her name, the part of the name that means shining this kind of thing. So we're told a little bit about her childhood. She ages sort of supernaturally quickly, grows up very fast up to be very beautiful, very kind of elegant and attractive to a lot of the men living around her. Sort of word gets out that there's this unmarried woman living with the bamboo cutter. And so she attracts the attention of a lot of different suitors.

We read that many of them kind of quickly lose interest as she refuses to see any of them until we have like the five main candidates left, who are these noblemen, right? They're either prominent political figures or princes, right? Members of a kind of royal family. And so here the story breaks off into these kind of what we might call embedded narratives. Right? Each one of these five suitors has his own quest that he's asked to go on, which is kind of prompted by *Kaguya* saying, "If you retrieve this exotic or legendary item for me, then I'll consider your request to marry me." And so she sends these five men out on what we might call like wild goose chases, right? Attempts to find objects that they really have no chance of actually finding.

Each one of them, they're looking for different things that you can read about as you go through the story. It would take us too long to talk through all of them. But they're each sent out to find one of these five things. They each, in their own kind of humorous way, fail to do so. Then this kind of middle part of the story ends and we have a sixth suitor, what we might call him, who turns out to be the emperor himself, the sovereign of Japan during this period, who also really wants to take *Kaguya* as his wife. So she rejects all five of those men, and then the emperor begins seeking her attention, trying to correspond with her as well. So you might think the emperor would succeed where the others have, but in fact this doesn't happen.

He's also rejected in the end, but they do begin a sort of how can we describe the relationship they have. It's not an antagonistic one, right? It's a kind of correspondence in among people that are willing to like hear the other one out, right? They have a friendship; they have a sort of relationship of sorts. It takes place entirely via letters sent from one to the other. They sort of write poems to one another; they send messages back and forth and this kind of thing. So if we're sort of thinking in terms of how fairy tales often play out, we might imagine, oh, what's gonna happen in this story is *Kaguya* is gonna finally find a suitable husband, and she'll marry him and they'll live happily ever

after.

But in fact that's not how the story works, right? Kaguya remains unmarried. She eventually reveals her true place of. She showed up in the bamboo, but where she's really from is the. And not only is she from the, but she's gonna have to go back there soon. She's sort of being summoned back to her original home on the moon. Both her adoptive father and the emperor vow to help her remain on earth, but to kind of quickly summarize a pretty dramatic, I guess what we could call like an action sequence at the end of the story, they're basically all of their efforts are unusable in face of these super powerful beings who come down from the moon to retrieve. Princess Kaguya. So she ends up leaving everybody behind.

She dons this feathered cloak that causes her to forget all of her experiences and attachments to the world as we know it and go back to where she comes from on the moon, leaving the bamboo cutter and the emperor back on, thinking about what they've lost, right? Thinking about this daughter, or friend, or potential bride that they're both kind of longing for. The emperor, then, in our version, is sort of granted a potion of immortality but very poignantly says, what's the point of living forever if I don't get to be with Kaguya? And then sends this bottle, sends a letter to the top of Mount Fuji or what comes to be known as Mount Fuji and burns it. And then we see that explains the kind of coming from the top of this volcanic mountain.

So this is the basic outline of the story. The part that I've summarized most densely, of course, being those embedded narratives when each of the suitors has their own sort of self-contained adventure in search of. So what else can we say about this story? Thinking more about beyond what happens in the story, thinking about, well, what is the story about? What's the significance of a story like this? One of the most striking things about it, I think, and something that I think remains. I don't know if enigmatic is the right word; ambiguous, open to interpretation, is just the kind of and behavior of Kaguya herself. She's kind of impossible to please. She doesn't necessarily seem snobby or picky or that she's being kind of cruel to these suitors. She's committed to remaining unwed.

She responds somewhat differently to different people, but is fairly resolute in this decision. And this, I think, is an open question, right? Why is it that she both rejects all of these suitors, and why is it that she wants to remain on Earth, despite being summoned back at the end of the story? These are questions that I think for our purposes. I don't really want to answer, right? I might have my own interpretation of this; I'm sure you have your own interpretation. I also think that this is part of what makes the story so rereadable, right? It's part of what keeps drawing people back to it, is just thinking about Kaguya as a fairly deep character, despite the fact that she doesn't really do a whole lot in the story, right?

Like a lot of the action of the story is decisions, or speeches, or things that are said by all of the people around her. And kind of at the middle of the story is the sort of enigmatic and captivating character of Princess Kaguya herself. But our attention for Most of the story is really drawn to these suitors and the different quests that they go on. This is a case in which you know you might imagine a storyteller could repurpose some parts of the story or like reinvent parts of the story. The

beginning and end of the story don't change, but you might want to change, you know, what are those objects. Who are these suitors? What kinds of adventures do they go on?

This is a really sort of fruitful, like very adaptable, very sort of malleable part of the story. And indeed, if you're familiar with other versions of the story, the objects and the people and the, you know, narratives in the section might be quite different from one version to the next. For our purpose, though, I think you know one of the most interesting things to think about in the case of this particular version is just to help us get a little bit more kind of basic foundation in the sources of cultural traditions, different practices that are going on in Heian Japan. So without going into too much detail about these specific objects right or who these people are, one thing that we can point out is that all of those five suitors come from like very high ranks in society.

Of course, the logic of the story explains this by saying that in addition to adopting Kaguya, as his daughter, the bamboo cutter also kind of starts to obtain great wealth and becomes like a very prominent kind of flashy house in his area. And so the attention of suitors he's attracting is not just everyday people, but it's these noblemen and government officials, right, hoping to have a sort of suitable match for their marriage. But beyond this, I think we can understand those court officials, those members of royal family, as part of a kind of cultural context in which the story circulates. You know, this doesn't necessarily define for us like where the story comes from, right? We could imagine this being a story told about the nobles from a kind of commoner perspective.

We could also imagine it as a story that's told and retold within this kind of elite cultural context. And I think there are sort of elements of truth to both of those possibilities, which we'll get into in more detail. But one thing we can think about for now is that this is, despite its kind of otherworldly elements, really set within the context of this elite court culture of government officials and noblemen in this period of Japanese history. In terms of the objects themselves, we get a really interesting blend of these sort of exotic objects from as far away as India or China. A few of the objects come from Japanese myths and legends, and so on. And there's lots of specific detail in there.

But I think, in general, this helps us to think about what are the kind of foundational features of Japanese culture at this point in history, right? We have very prominent representation of Buddhism as both a religion and as a kind of collection of lore, right? They're sort of objects or artifacts that are associated with Buddhist history, the begging bowl of the Buddha being one of them. We see elements of kind of Confucian and Taoist philosophical and religious traditions, as well as some more local stories and so on. So there's a kind of interesting blending of what is represented within the story as exotic, what's represented within the story as local, but still sort of hard to come by, combining these kind of international and local cultural traditions that at this point in Japanese history would be very kind of commonplace.

Right? This is the sort of situation that's the case for many different kinds of Japanese literature and culture in this period, kind of combining elements from all of these different places. So one thing to think about because we're dealing with a phase of Japanese history in which Buddhism by way of India, China, and is already very well established in Japan. We might think about, well, which

of those cultural elements are really treated as foreign. So the begging bowl of the Buddha is a physical object associated with the very early history of Indian Buddhist teachings of the historical Buddha himself. It is something that's presented as very impossible to find, very difficult to come by. And yet, there are other details of this narrative, this idea of a cycle of rebirth, an idea about karmic retribution that are not necessarily treated as foreign or exotic.

These are fully adapted to Japanese society that would have been familiar and not understood as coming from very far away or being hard to understand at this point in history. And the other kind of interesting thing about this is thinking about the stone in the dragon's head. It's kind of presented as a locally occurring fantastic beast. This dragon is not found in another country. It's not found hundreds of miles away. It's found off the coast of Japanese islands. We might contrast this against the cape or cloak of the fire rat, the fur of the fire rat, which is something that you do need to go all the way to China to retrieve. And yet when we think about the image of the, of course, this.

is something a sort of concept of a fantastic creature that's formed through a lot of cross-cultural elements coming from Chinese legendary traditions being brought into Japan and so on. So there's this kind of interesting blend of different cultural elements that are presented in the story, some of which are being shown to us as things that come from very far away that are seen as kind of foreign or exotic. Others are presented as being more sort of closer at hand. And yet even those kind of local things are still the product of a kind of complex cultural exchange that's taken place earlier in history. So I don't think that that particular detail is central to the significance of this story necessarily, but it does kind of help us think about the general context in which stories like this were created, kind of filling us in on a little bit more cultural contextual detail about this period of Japanese history.

So yeah, which are kind of presented as being locally occurring objects. So moving on to a few more things to think about. Here, I'd like us to think about a kind of narrative element, right? The way that the end of the story, as I pointed out, kind of functions as an explanation of both the name of Mount Fuji and a sort of particular feature of it. At this point in history that there's a kind of plume of smoke coming out of the top of it. So in a way, we can think of the sort of purpose of the story, right? If we're thinking about the ending as a really significant part, this is a kind of long and roundabout way of explaining, well, why does Mount Fuji have smoke coming out of it?

Why is Mount Fuji called that? So we might sort of think about, oh, this is maybe one purpose that the story has, right? Then this kind of element, this sort of concluding with the of some cultural or geographic phenomenon is also part of those embedded narratives themselves, right? Some of these are the way Donald Keene refers to this in his analysis of the story. He says that these are facetious origin phrases, right? That is, that they're false. Now, would these have been taken as false origin stories at the time, or would people have read it and said, oh okay, so that's where this phrase comes from? Is there some humor in the way these are presented? All of these are possibilities, right? Some analysis and interpretation might shed some more light on this.

The main thing I wanna point out is that this is a kind of narrative device that recurs throughout

the, that sort of treats the preceding embedded narrative as the explanation of where a particular phrase or expression comes from another kind of broader recurring element in the story, and one of the things that connects this narrative to a lot of other myths and legends and from really all around the world is what scholars of folklore and storytelling have called this like swan maiden plot or like swan maiden archetype. Within a, so what scholars have found who've looked at folklore from a lot of different places is that there's a kind of recurring narrative that's not, you know, this isn't to say that oh this story of Princess Kaguya is one that reappears word for word in lots of other cultural traditions, but there's.

a kind of plot that we see repeated not just in this story but in stories that otherwise have nothing to do with the story of Kaguya, in which we tend to see the same basic elements. Right? There's a woman who comes from some otherworldly realm. She initially had what, in a lot of versions, is a right, it's a feather cloak that maybe makes her look like a swan. Right? It's a sort of feather cloak disguise; she loses, so then her true form is revealed. She is pursued by different suitors. In a lot of the other versions of the story, or sort of other uses of this plot, the swan maiden is then married to a She may even give birth to, like, human children.

sort of, you know, leaving behind this trace of her existence, but eventually, at the end of the story, she like regains this feathered cloak that conceals her identity again, and then either causes her to disappear or causes her to, you know, return back to wherever it is that she came from. And so this is a kind of a theme or plot that comes up in stories throughout East Asia and, you know, now all over the world, right? And there are lots of interesting theories about where this comes from, what part of the world does it originate in, how does it spread through history, how did these different sort of branching paths form? What happens to the story once some of those you know branching paths come in contact with one another once again.

Once people sort of realize that there are these kind of recurring themes throughout mythologies and sort of legendary traditions that are otherwise totally unrelated, you can see how this is a very captivating thing to for scholars of folklore, anthropology, and storytelling, and all of these things. Yet, because what we're dealing with is you, these kind of very foundational elements of myths and legends, it's hard to say anything too conclusive about this. But this is certainly a topic that at a certain point in let's say you know, 1980s, 1990s, there was a lot of scholarship done on this kind of like classification of different shared elements of myths and legends, right? If we kind of boil those legends down to their essential elements, we see that they have a lot more in common with one another than might seem to be the case.

We're thinking about the kind of culturally specific particular details that appear in each of them. But there's a kind of core question at the heart of this, right? Does the existence of those shared elements mean that all of them share some kind of primordial ancestor, right? Are we talking about a story that was invented in one place and then over many, many centuries kind of spread out until it could be found throughout really, really broad regions of the world. This is one possibility. Or maybe even more mysteriously, is there something that's just kind of like universally compelling about stories like this that may have been invented at different points in time completely unrelated to one another just based on things that people like to talk about, right?

Sort of independently invented and yet coincidentally, or maybe not, sort of similar to one another in all of these different places. I don't know, I'm not sure what the sort of prevailing theories on this is, but it's certainly you can see how it's something that might inspire a lot of kind of research and speculation and analysis of these sort of shared themes across storytelling traditions all around the feature that scholars have been really captivated by when doing research on stories like this, kind of trying to connect them to others that also have this what's come to be known as the swan maiden structure. Keeping in mind the idea that the story draws on very ancient, very sort of widespread motifs and themes that we can see in a lot of other literary traditions around the world, you can start to see how this question of where the story comes from is very hard to answer conclusively.

So, if we're talking about where does that element of the story come from, well, there's lots of theories, lots of speculation about this that we don't need to go into for our purposes. Instead, what I'd like to focus on is this particular version of the story, the sort of written form that we are reading again in English translation, but based on what we are fairly confident is a kind of consistent manuscript tradition going back to the early 10th century. So, thinking again about the kind of formative elements of the story, there are some texts. from before the early 10th century that seem to be presenting versions of this story, whether they're referring to a girl who appears in bamboo or some other thing.

They appear to be references to a kind of story that's not just another sort of swan maiden archetype, but something that sort of resembles the story as we know it today. We can see a sort of spotty references, no full versions, but there's some idea that this may in fact be a little bit older than the early 10th century. But it's hard to say for sure based on those kind of references. This story itself doesn't have a credited author. This is not as unusual as it might seem. Thinking in terms of contemporary literary traditions, this is, for the most part, the case of a lot of narratives, especially both in pre-modern East Asia as well as other parts of the world.

This idea that a single historical individual needs to be credited as the author of especially a piece of storytelling is a relatively recent development. Sort of, you know, key elements of this idea in Japanese history start to show up not that long after this story has been written. But in this case, the fact that the story is anonymously composed, it's not too surprising. Many people have still attempted to figure out, you know, who is most likely among the historical figures that we're aware of, who is most likely to have been the one responsible for producing the version of the story as we know it. I don't know that there's a whole lot of consensus on, you know, who this person is.

I would imagine that at this point most people understand it to be a kind of evolving tradition that, sure, maybe one individual was responsible for most of what we see in the version we have today, but it's pretty unlikely that we'll ever have, you know, very conclusive evidence about who that person was. So beyond that, beyond thinking about, you know, the individuals responsible for producing the text of the version that we read today, it is fairly clear that this story combines elements of other narratives and kind of common patterns in folklore. So again, the swan maiden structure is one of them. Within those embedded narratives, we can also see references to sort of

objects, or ideas, or sort of narrative patterns that show up in other places as well, right?

So we can think of this as kind of a composite story that draws on existing folktales, existing probably oral traditions, and then sort of weaves them together to create a consistent, you know. The other sort of interesting challenge with studying text like this. you know we're studying the text in written form. Ideally, we would want a traceable manuscript tradition that goes all the way back to when we think the story comes from. This is almost universally the case when we're talking about very early literary history. We don't actually have this right. We don't have a piece of paper or silk or whatever would be written on that scholars say, like, oh, this object is from the 10th century, and this contains the complete text of our story.

Therefore, we know it comes from the 10th century, right? This is almost never the case in literature for this period. So this might seem, you know, kind of mysterious. or confusing, but this is very common in pre-modern literary traditions. The oldest, like traceable lineages of manuscripts that we have. So we could say, like, oh this text that we have today is based on this text that comes, you know, a generation before it, and so on, and so on, and so on. This only takes us back about as far as like the late 1500s, right? This is when we have a fairly concrete idea of the different written versions of this text in sort of physical manuscript form. This is a kind of complex idea. I'll return to it in unit two.

But this creates another uncertainty, right? How is the story like preserved and transmitted from the 10th century up until when we have a more traceable manuscript history is sort of a question that's worthy of consideration. So, setting aside those uncertainties, how is it that we're able to determine that you know fairly well agreed upon date of 909 CE? How is it that we know that this is where the story comes from? One of the really interesting points that people have made about this is that you know Fuji is, I guess, what we could call like an active volcano. Luckily, it hasn't erupted catastrophically for the past couple centuries. It was, at one point in time, somewhat more active. There was a sort of period of time where we know.

from kind of contemporary contemporaneous sources that around 905 CE smoke the smoke that would have been visible over the top of the mountain kind of ceased. And by briefly I mean, you know, decades, perhaps even longer. Later eruptions of the mountain obviously would have caused more sort of visible smoke and that kind of thing above it. But there's a kind of very interesting reference in another, like equally early text that around the year 905 smoke stopped coming out of the top. So if we have this, you know, presumably very familiar element to the story of like oh this is where the smoke at the top of Mount Fuji comes from We might assume, okay, the story needs to have been written at some point in time when this was actually going on.

There's also some thinking that tells us that the names of the suitors are kind of figures from the mid-ninth century. This is another thing that's, you know, maybe kind of debated about, but some sort of historical references within the text have been used to kind of tell us who are people that are referred to in this work. And again, this doesn't tell us, it doesn't give us an end date, but it does give us a kind of beginning date, right? So it could not have been composed prior to knowledge about those historical figures, but It could have been composed any point after they

were available within history books to write about for other people. Right? So there are these kind of, we can sort of set up some polls to say here are the two edges, boundaries for this story.

We also know, and this is where the kind of 909 date comes from, there's much more sort of definitive reference to the story in a poem that can be pretty conclusively dated to 909. Sort of lingering question we might ask, though the story, the poem doesn't tell us every single detail of the story as we know it today. Right? So we might still wonder, maybe some elements of the tradition kind of entered. the narrative entered the manuscript tradition after this, but there's some reference to the story being made. And 909 points out the bamboo cutter, points out all of these other things about it. And it's kind of presented as something that people would have known about at that point in.

So much more conclusively, much more detail is provided by the sort of repeated references to the story in a very famous work of Japanese literature, widely understood to be very early example of the novel. You know, very long, hundreds of page long narrative that has a similarly kind of episodic structure, but also tells a story over the course. Of its many chapters, from around the early 11th, the narratives within Tale of Genji kind of returned to on a couple of different occasions. People who are reading or talking about or discussing, evaluating the story of the bamboo cutter. And so, at this point in time, about a hundred years after when we think the story was kind of put down in writing in the form that we know it today, it's become a kind of well-known story that everybody in the novel is kind of familiar with.

And it's even one that's being presented, in some cases, which we'll talk about in the next unit, as kind of old-fashioned or outdated in relation to some other stories. that are being written closer in time to Tale of Genji itself, right? So this is a kind of classic story, for better or for worse, by the time this other book is out there. So, based on all of this, the kind of consensus that we can arrive at is that this is an anonymously composed story that combines elements of what are likely to be much older legends and mythic traditions, and yet which we kind of think to have been written down in roughly the same form that we know it today, around the early 900s.

But, of course, we have to keep in mind that following from that, the story continues to change and evolve. Again, by evolve, I don't mean get better. I don't mean improve; I just mean sort of change according to different circumstances in later history. So we have all of these sort of like parallel versions, some of which perhaps emerging from these much older legends and myths that share sort of similar themes. Others, what we might think of as kind of branching paths. Someone perhaps read the version that we read and then created their own new version of it, and so on. So there's this kind of complex web of related versions of this narrative. But the text of the story that we read for this unit is largely thought to have taken shape sometime in the early 10th century.

So working from this as our baseline, right? What can we say about why the story was written this form? What can we say about what does the story means, right? What's the significance of a story like this? The first thing I'd like us to think about is to consider the difference between these two questions, right? The purpose for something coming into existence is going to tell us something about the story. It doesn't necessarily tell us everything about the story, right? The sort of meaning

is something that sort of occurs to us as readers, right? We might agree about a lot of those elements. We might disagree about others. But these are things that are kind of harder to pin down in both cases.

At the same time, this question of why something was written is hard to answer conclusively, right? Because we sort of work from our own interpretation of the story and kind of think back and say, oh okay, like based on what I understand about the story, what is something that a 10th-century storyteller would have thought that they were achieving by telling a story like this, right? Very kind of complex question of interpretation and analysis is presented to us from these two very simple questions. So one thing, for example, that may not occur to us very naturally is an idea that this version of the story right. The one that has all of these embedded narratives, that has its own particular, you know, ups and downs, and even like proper nouns within it that might not appear in all of the others.

Some have made very interesting arguments that this story is actually a kind of political satire that you can kind of look at either the names of the figures or perhaps look at some wordplay going on with how these characters are referred to, that they're sort of veiled references to historical figures. We know, of course, that those suitors all fail in their task in some humorous, some kind of tragic ways. We might interpret the sort of details of those narratives, a form of like critique or satire about either those historical figures, if they can be connected with people who actually lived, perhaps with their descendants. Right, there's a sort of fairly compelling line of interpretation that connects some of these figures with these kind of prominent families in what would have been like contemporary a hay on court culture of the day.

Right, so we're reading it as a kind of thinly veiled critique of contemporary society in this 10th century context. But on top of that, it also has this other feature that we've addressed. Right, that there's these. sort of elements of wordplay and an interest in explaining origins. Right, I think this is also something that might be very easy for us to overlook: looking for emotional themes, looking for sort of dramatic resonance, looking for all of the themes— things that we tend to look at when we analyze literature— as contemporary readers might dismiss those origin story elements as insignificant or kind of meaningless. Right, in translation, they don't really work so well. It's even harder to see what's going on with those phrases. But I think we shouldn't dismiss these as like important components of this version of the story.

Right. Whether these are serious, right? Whether this is a kind of folk etymology that's attempting to sort of excavate the actual origins of sort of different terms of phrase, or whether these are meant to be jokes that the contemporary audience would just sort of be like lightly amused by when they read it. We don't need to be so conclusive about this, but I do think we shouldn't ignore the significance of those as a kind of like narrative device within the story itself. And so, these are two elements that I think that we as contemporary readers might be a bit too quick to overlook as possibilities deeper we get into kind of cultural. and linguistic context, we might see more support for an argument like this.

But of course, the story is more than just these elements, right? The story has some features that

recur over and over and over again, even though the names of the people or the kind of identities of those five objects might also change. It also has some elements that are particular to this version of the story that might shift or change in other retellings. And here we get into some of the other complexity about asking: what does it mean? Does every version of the story mean the same thing? Do they all have the same significance? Is there a core theme that we can say yes, this is the purpose that all of these different versions of the story across time and space all share.

Perhaps, although for my purposes, I'm usually uncomfortable going quite that far and saying this is the core meaning of the story. This is the moral lesson it's teaching. And no matter what you change about all of these other elements, every version of the Bamboo Cutter story shares this one particular theme. I, in fact, don't really think that this is true. I much prefer a more sort of open-ended interpretation of this, which says that each version of the story might mean something slightly different. They can sort of bring out different elements of the themes that might appear in one way or another throughout all versions of the story. But we need to pay attention to how those are presented within the context of each version.

So one thing that I do think is true about this story is that it doesn't seem to have a very clearly expressed moral. Unlike a lot of fairy tales, it doesn't say like, oh, because of what happened in the story of Princess Kaguya, this is how we should live our lives today. I don't really think the story is allegorical in that sense. And I don't think that it ends in a way that is really sort of compelling its reader to then take up a certain kind of like ethical position in response to the things that happened. This doesn't mean that there aren't elements of morality and ethics and sort of messages or values in the story. I just think that it's not quite so simple that we can say, oh, the purpose of the story is to teach us to be like this.

We might, in the process of reading it, sort of have some ideas occur to us, but it's not as though the story ends by saying, and this is why you should always do this. You should always maintain this kind of perspective. So, setting aside that sort of single and clearly expressed moral of the story, where else can we look for meaning? in the story One thing that a lot of people have focused on relates to this idea of impermanence, the sense that all of the stuff in our life is one way going, is one day or another going to disappear. We can't hold on to any of these things forever. And we see this not only sort of recurring throughout the different stages of the story

but really quite explicitly at the end when Kaguya draws the feathered cloak and is sort of, in a weird way, given this gift but also the sort of tragedy of having all of her memories of her life on earth stripped away from her, so that she can return to this other realm. We might think of this as something that's kind of sad even while we recognize that that sadness is not something that the princess herself is able to experience because she's left behind all of those things that she's become attached to here on earth. But this is also kind of with what I find to be a fairly consistent melancholic state of mind throughout the story, both within Kaguya herself. She wants to stay on earth.

She's sort of committed to her bond with her father. She rejects these suitors, which to me sort of looks like a kind of dissatisfaction with the things that she's encountering, right? So she is in some

ways committed to living this life of hers. that she has on earth, but in other ways is never really satisfied by it. So there's the sense of longing, or melancholy, or a kind of unevenness of her interests throughout the story. And then again, at the end of the story, this is really, you know, becomes the defining trait of this emperor character, right? Who loses the one thing that he really wants, is given this option of living forever, but realizes it's not going to be the way that he wants it to be if he can't get, you know, the woman that he wants to be with.

So I think these are kind of related ideas. I think these are themes that occur in this version of the story, as well as in other tellings. of it. And yet, I don't know that you know what's the message of this, right? I think it's just a kind of idea that resonates with us, perhaps something that we felt, right? A sort of sense of displacement within the world, something like this, right? Thinking a bit more concretely, thinking in terms of themes that often occur in other myths and legends, there are lots of sort of interesting ideas, interesting arguments that are made about a feature of a lot of different storytelling traditions in a lot of different parts of the world, are about oaths, right?

About saying that you're going to do something and then either keeping your word that oath or breaking it. And then the kind of consequences of breaking the oath, right? So we can think about those embedded narratives as stories about people who have expressed an oath that, yes, I am going to go off and retrieve this thing. And then they deal with the consequences of being unable to fulfill that. So when we kind of distill a narrative down to that really kind of core structure, all of a sudden this is a kind of story pattern that we can see recurring over and over again throughout lots of different traditions. Again, as is the case with the Swan Maiden narrative, does this mean that all of these stories of broken.

oaths kind of emerge from a single primordial story that then branches off and forms all these others. Maybe, maybe it's also just an idea that's sort of compelling to us as people that live within a society that kind of depends on people who can keep their word, right? Thinking about the significance of making an oath and keeping it. And so this is another sort of source of meaning in the story that we might focus on. Of course, this is also a story about a father and his daughter and about the kind of bonds that exist between parents and children, about these kind of adoptive families, about the nature of parenthood, the nature of Being a child of someone, does this depend on bloodlines? Does it depend on other factors?

What is it that sort of creates these bonds among family members? Certainly, this is something we can think about being expressed in different ways and kind of different versions of the story. And I think, though, it's also important to point out that there are, like, elements of humor to the story as well. You know, I've been talking about some kind of heavy themes, you know, impermanence and melancholy— all of this. I hope you didn't get the impression that this is a very serious or kind of dour story. This is one in which there's like wordplay; there's jokes, there are some kind of slapstick elements. The consequences of these broken oaths often, in this case, end up being a kind of humorous, the kind of collapse of society.

So, certainly, those elements of humor are another important part of the story. Thinking sort of laterally, to some other elements scholars have pointed out about the story is the way that there's

a kind of recurring theme of exile, whether we're talking about Kaguya herself or some of these suitors and what happens to them in the wake of their sort of failure to achieve these things and other kinds of events that take place in the story. And so, on the one hand there's this idea of being cast out of a place due to something that you've done or what people think about you, which we could call exile. On the other hand, there's also embodied most clearly in Kaguya's refusal to wed any of these people, this refusal of that elite court culture, right?

And where we might start to think about, well, how does this story satirize Heian society, might kind of focus on this aspect of it, right? That Kaguya is kind of given the opportunity to join this community of aristocrats and princes, and so on. And yet she kind of sees right through who they are. They don't impress her. This kind of world doesn't appeal to her. She rejects it, right? We might think of her as one who refuses this Heian elite society in favor of other things. We might also think about the sort of climax of the story in which the emperor and her father and all of these other forces are really doing everything they can to keep Kaguya with them.

And all of the sort of might of the emperor's army and all of these other figures is proven to be totally useless and ineffective in the face of the kind of super powered beings from the moon who present a kind of alternative— another kind of alternative— to the Heian court, right? A kind of superior capital from beyond the world as we know it. That kind of makes our own world feel very small and weak. So, we might think about this as sort of contributing to the satirical or critical elements of the story. So again, all of these are good possibilities. All of these present sort of interesting avenues of interpretation. These are certainly not mutually exclusive. We can say all of these are kind of elements that appear within the story.

And this is why I find that sort of limiting to say, 'Oh no, it's in fact just this one idea.' Right? Really, we can set aside all of this other stuff and say all this is a story about impermanence. I think when we do that, we lose sight of all of these other elements that are quite compelling that also appear in the story. Let's bring some of this together a little bit, and let's think about how this is going to connect with the other two units of this module. So one of the conclusive things we could say about the story in its earliest form is that it's anonymously composed and that it's a composite story, right?

It sort of takes shape at the culmination of a lot of pre-existing influences in Japanese culture, and it combines elements of older myths and legends, many of which probably would have been spread through oral transmission across a spectrum of society. But also includes some pretty clear indicators of, like, hallmarks of this, like, elite literate community. And these are what allow us to think of it as a kind of satire or critique of Heian court culture, either written by people living within it or people kind of just outside of it, right? The kinds of critiques that would be interesting to make if you have some stake in what's going on in that elite society. We know also that it is available to readers in roughly this form since the early 900s.

We know it to have become a very familiar story since about a thousand years later, with the sort of assumption that we can make that sometime. During this period, awareness of the story spread pretty quickly. But we also know that we access it today through a manuscript tradition that goes

back to about the 1500s and then becomes a bit more spotty before that. This is something we'll be talking about in a bit more detail, sort of exploring some of the consequences of this the next unit. We also know that, in addition to what is like a fairly like small or sort of low variation textual transmission, in which some elements may change and shift, we can say that this is the sort of lineage of the story going back to that early 10th century context.

And we also know that both before and after this there's lots of other versions or sort of related stories, perhaps just growing more numerous in number the closer to the present we get. So those adaptations are also going to form part of our discussion in units two and three. So what we'll be doing then is thinking about how those adaptations both like add depth and new layers to some of those themes or recurring elements that I was just introducing, all of these very compelling features that I think make the story engaging and interesting to us no matter what point in time we're looking at. You know this critique of Heian court culture of might have been very compelling to people in the 10th century.

For me personally, I have no stake in this; you know, maybe that's not going to draw me into the story. But there are other elements about it that we might think of as kind of inspiring— all of these later adaptations catching the attention of new audiences. And we can think about how those later adaptations, or sort of parallel adaptations, might even change our understanding; they might give a new layer of significance to the story that isn't really part of the version that we just read. Or we might find that they kind of pick up on one of these more subtle details and really use. that as the kind of seed from which to create a narrative with like a slightly different focus.

So this is one of the very fascinating things about studying adaptations: we can think about how the later version might sort of draw our attention to some aspect of the older version that may not have occurred even to the people who wrote it in the first place. But before we look at those adaptations, I'd like us to stay focused until the end of this unit on the single version of the text we read for today and start trying to make some broader thematic connections to other myths and legends. So what I'd like us to do for the writing assignment for this unit is to just think of some other example of a story that you're familiar with that this one kind of reminded you of.

Now for this purpose, one of those may be perhaps you've already seen the Princess Kaguya film from 2013. These kinds of things set them aside for now. We can come back to them later. I'd like us not to think about anything that we can consider another version of the same story, but instead think about some kind of parallel themes or parallel elements in tales that, as far as you know, are more or less unrelated. This might be something that we've encountered in an earlier module of the class. It might be something that you're familiar with from your own childhood, from another course you've Anything is fine, but I'd like you to think of some other example of a myth, legend, or folktale that shares some element with some part of this one that we've read today.

And then I'd like you to just write up a short comparison of those two things. Introduce the new source you're talking about, and as we're often asked to do in this class, think about those similarities and what it is it that calls this other example to mind for you. And yet how can you distinguish between the two of them? So what's the same, what's different, and why do you? think

this matters. Again, potential for a much longer, in-depth essay here. A couple of paragraphs, though, is more than long enough for this kind of writing assignment. Then, for the quiz, as usual, more concrete, more focused on just details and recalling information. Like the others, this one is gonna be five questions. You'll have 10 minutes to complete it.

Some of the questions will relate to these broader conceptual historical issues that have come up in my lecture. Many of them are gonna come from the story itself. And for these, you will need to have read the story to answer them, but I'll try to be— I'll try to be kind in the way I phrase. the questions I'm not gonna ask you to memorize. What is the name of the suitor who is seeking this particular object? I will refer to details from the but there'll be questions that are written in a way that I hope anyone who's read the story carefully and retained memory of it will be able to without having taken really elaborate notes on who is doing what, what their rank in the court is.

Those kinds of things are all far too precise for a quiz like this, but the questions will be inspired by elements from the story that I have not mentioned directly in this lecture. So do please read the story before taking the All right, and as Usual, at the end of this PowerPoint presentation, you can see a slide that has some recommendations for further reading in case you'd like to read more, in particular about the sort of early history of the story. All right, thanks everybody, and I'll see you back for the lecture in the next unit.